

6, The Fulani Jihads in the West African Sahel

I would like to further discuss the Fulani Jihads in West Africa. Although I believe this monumental historical event essentially remains a case of a "**awaiting feudalization**" backward people utilizing Islam to undergo **feudalization**, because it occurred at such a late era, Western influence had already conspicuously emerged along the entire African coastline. Therefore, alongside internal factors, the genesis of the Fulani Jihads was obviously driven by significant external factors.

For example, I noticed that one of the fundamental political demands raised by the Jihad's initiator, Usman dan Fodio (丹-福迪奥), was tax relief and the strict prohibition of enslaving Muslims. Why was this the case?

When Europeans arrived in Africa, slaves became the most coveted commodity on the continent. The indigenous states along the Guinea coast imported European weapons and manufactured goods, and in turn, sold slaves acquired through warfare and slave-raiding back to the Europeans. This constituted one leg of the infamous Triangular Trade.

As the coastal Black nations gradually grew powerful through their interactions with Europe, they cast their gaze toward the relatively backward inland Africa, utilizing martial force to harvest slaves there. Thus, even the inland regions were violently dragged into the international slave trade.

At that time, inland Africa was fractured into a multitude of small states; their intrinsic power was weak, and they were incapable of forming alliances. Consequently, coastal indigenous states, and subsequently European powers, could acquire slaves from the African interior at staggeringly low costs. Even if we set aside the extreme backwardness and inhumanity of slavery and merely view slaves as a "commodity," we can say that the entire inland Africa was trapped in a supra-economic disadvantageous position within international trade, simply because this commodity was far too cheap!

If a formidable regime could unify the inland region—just as the later Sokoto Caliphate (索科托哈里发国) did by annexing dozens of West African native states as its vassals—then this regime would effectively monopolize the commodity of slaves, genuinely elevating its bargaining power (议价权) in the international market.

Such demands indeed summoned the ambitious warlords of the inland regions to make their attempts, and Islam, functioning as an ideological and organizational weapon, undeniably proved immensely helpful.

The regions where the Jihads originated were not areas in direct contact with the West at the time; they were "**secondary contact zones**" (次级接触地带), meaning they could only interact via the regions of direct contact. The Western powers often underestimated the impact of these Jihads when they erupted, and geographical distance weakened their willingness and capacity to intervene. Thus, these secondary contact zones indeed found the opportunity to form a unified, massive state.

However, although such a regime makes a plethora of glittering promises when seizing the realm—and indeed, a small fraction of "revolutionary heroes" believe in these idealistic slogans until their dying breath—the **reality is inevitably that the state swiftly devolves into the very entity it once opposed!** It utilizes its monopoly over a specific international commodity to consolidate its rule.

Therefore, we can observe that although the Fulani Jihads indeed proclaimed the vision of opposing slavery at their inception, the reality is that the state rapidly mutated into a colossal slave-holding empire. By 1850, the Sokoto Caliphate was the second-largest slave-holding region in the entire world, trailing only the American South!

(Of course, this is merely speaking formally, as the definition of a "slave" varies wildly across the globe. If you ask me, by 1850, the absolute largest slave-holding region in the world was undeniably China! The second was likely India, whose total population was second only to China's, even though the British had already officially abolished slavery in India in 1843).

After the American Civil War, Sokoto leaped to first place. Possessing a Muslim identity fundamentally could not prevent impoverished commoners from being reduced to slaves.

A "**Fulani-style state**" (富拉尼式国家) formed in this manner can never deliver true national liberation; it merely centralizes previously scattered exploitation! The region's disadvantageous position within the international division of labor remains utterly unchanged. Its ruler is not so much the leader of a nation as the chief overseer of a "**sweatshop**" (血汗工厂).

Maintaining the current system allows the state to become powerful in the short term. Setting everything else aside, the surge in fiscal revenue is sufficient to enable a Fulani-style state to build an armed force with a "**façade of modernization**" (表面现代化), invest in infrastructure, and partially ameliorate people's livelihoods. However, this simultaneously forges a massive vested interest group and exacerbates path dependency. Not to mention, since the very foundation of the state relied on the assistance of a radical ideology, the rulers must constantly contrive ways to prove its superiority and cannot possibly abandon their founding ethos immediately. Consequently, the greater the initial achievements the state secures, the exponentially harder it becomes to genuinely modernize. Since such a state struggles to generate true technological progress, and its society remains light-years away from a modern society, the moment the rulers face a crisis, their only recourse is to intensify the exploitation of their own people, which conversely **exacerbates the social crisis**.

To be honest, writing up to this point, it is practically impossible for any reader familiar with the modern history of East Asia not to experience a profound sense of déjà vu. When we look at the historical river of the 20th century and observe a certain colossal nation—having endured violent social upheavals—similarly utilizing a radical ideology to achieve an extreme concentration of power; when it leverages its massive population scale and the extreme extraction termed the "**demographic dividend**" (人口红利) to conjure a miracle of "**rejuvenation**" (复兴) in the short term that shocks outsiders, it is not difficult to realize what the true underlying color of this so-called "historical leap" actually is. The ultra-economic extraction it conducts is even more efficient and ruthless than that of the old eras it overthrew. History has proven time and again that any regime forcibly ripened by relying on this model will ultimately exhaust the true underlying substance of its society, making it difficult to possess a future leading to tomorrow.

Finally, some might harbor doubts: *Since the Sokoto Caliphate later devolved into a massive slave-holding region, is it still rational to categorize the Fulani Jihads as an Islamic social movement of early **feudalization**?*

My answer is: **It remains entirely rational**. First, we have already pointed out that the **feudalization** of the Sahel occurred far too late. European influence had inevitably emerged, and the

existence of such a massive slave population in the Caliphate was directly dictated by these external factors. Second, the commencement of an endeavor does not guarantee it will culminate in a perfect ending. It is not as if China never commenced *feudalization*—but look at where it is now! Third, whether judging from the Fulani rulers utilizing Islam to wage holy wars back then, or the current reality where the Fulani people are widely distributed across West Africa, maintaining economic dominance over other local ethnic groups, and forcing cohabiting ethnic groups to become "Fulanized" (富拉尼化)—the process of *feudalization* obviously occurred to a certain extent.

As for further evidence, it awaits supplementation by others; after all, attempting to comprehend the history and reality of West African society from within China is indeed exceptionally difficult.

6，西非萨赫勒地区的富拉尼圣战

我还想再提一下西非的富拉尼圣战，虽然我认为这一宏大的历史事件在本质上仍是待封建化落后民族利用伊斯兰教进行封建化。不过因为它发生的时代实在太晚，西方的影响已经显著地出现在整个非洲的海岸线上，因此富拉尼圣战的产生除了内部因素以外显然还有不小的外部因素。例如我注意到圣战的发起者丹-福迪奥（Usman dan Fodio）提出的一个基本政治诉求就是减免税收，不允许将穆斯林抓为奴隶，为什么会这样？当欧洲人来到非洲时，奴隶成为了这片大陆最受欢迎的商品，几内亚沿岸的土著国家输入欧洲的武器和手工业制品，并将通过战争和捕奴获得的奴隶卖给欧洲人，这构成了三角贸易的其中一角。沿海黑人国家通过与欧洲的交流逐渐强大起来，他们就会将目光投向此时显得更加落后的内陆非洲，凭借武力在这里获得奴隶，这样即使内陆地区也开始卷入国际性的奴隶贸易当中。当时内陆非洲小国林立，原本力量弱小还无法形成联合，因此海岸各土著国继而是欧洲各国都能够以过低的成本从非洲内陆获得奴隶。即使我们抛开奴隶制度的极端落后和非人道而仅把奴隶视为一种商品，就这样也可以说整个内陆非洲在国际贸易中处于超经济的不利局面，因为这种商品或许太廉价了。假如有一个强大政权能够统一内陆地区，就比如后来的索科托哈里发国将西非几十个土邦都并为自己的臣属，那么这个政权就在事实上垄断了奴隶这种商品，它在国际市场的议价权确实上升了。

这样的需求确实号召内陆地区的豪杰做出尝试，而伊斯兰教作为一种思想和组织上的武器无疑帮了大忙。圣战发起的地区在当时不属于跟西方直接接触的地带，而是次级接触地带，也就是只能通过直接接触地区进行交流。列强在圣战发生的时候往往容易低估其影响，同时地理上的遥远也削弱了它们的干涉意愿和能力，于是次级接触地区确实有机会形成统一大国。然而这样的政权虽然在其夺取天下时会做出一大堆承诺，也的确有少部分“革命英雄”至死都相信理想主义的口号，但是现实一定是这个国家迅速走向了他们曾经反对的一方，利用对某种国际商品的垄断地位来巩固自己的统治。因此我们可以看到虽然富拉尼圣战开始的时候的确提出过反对奴隶制的愿景，但事实是这个国家迅速成为一个庞大的蓄奴国家，到 1850 年为止索科托哈里发国（Sokoto Caliphate）已经是全世界除美国南部以外的第二大蓄奴区（不过这也就是说而已，毕竟全世界各地对于奴隶怎样定义差别极大。如果要我说，1850 年全世界最大的蓄奴区非中国莫属，其次恐怕是总人口次于中国的印度，哪怕英国人 1843 年就已经官方地废除了印度的奴隶制）。在美国南北战争之后跃居第一，穆斯林身份也不能够妨碍穷苦百姓被贬为奴隶。

像这样形成的“富拉尼式国家”不可能带来真正的民族解放，它只不过是把分散的剥削集中起来罢了，整个地区在国际分工中的不利地位没有改变，其统治者与其说是一个国家的领导人，不如说是一个“血汗工厂”的总监工。维持现有体制让国家短期内变得强大，抛开别的不谈，财政收入的增加足以使得富拉尼式的国家建设一支“表面现代化”的武装，投入基础设施建设并部分改良人们的生活。但是如此既形成了一个庞大的既得利益集团又加剧了路径依赖。更不要提整个国家最初的建立就依赖于激进意识形态的帮助，统治者必然要设法证明其优越性而不可能马上抛弃立国之基。于是整个国家最初取得的成就

越大，它想要近现代化就越加艰难。这样的国家既然难以创造真正的技术进步，其社会又与近现代社会相去甚远，统治者一旦面临危机就只能加大对本国人民的剥削，这反过*加剧了社会危机。其实写到这里，任何熟悉东亚近现代史的读者，都不可能不产生一种强烈的既视感。当我们在 20 世纪的历史长河中，看到某个庞大的国家在经历了剧烈的社会动荡后，同样借助某种激进的意识形态完成了权力的极度集中；当它凭借其巨大的人口体量和被称为“人口红利”的极致榨取，在短期内营造出令外人惊诧的“复兴”奇迹时，我们就不难意识到，这种所谓的“历史跨越”，其底色究竟是什么。它所进行的超经济强制榨取，甚至比它所推翻的那些旧有时代还要高效且冷酷。历史已经无数次证明，任何依赖这种模式强行催熟的政权，最终都将耗尽社会的真正底蕴，难以拥有通向未来的前途。

最后，或许会有人怀疑既然索科托哈里发国日后成为庞大的蓄奴区，那么把富拉尼圣战归类为封建化早期的伊斯兰社会运动是否合理。我的回答是仍然合理，第一我们已经指出萨赫勒带的封建化实在过晚，欧洲的影响已经不可避免地出现，哈里发国存在如此庞大的奴隶群体就是受到外部因素的影响。第二是某项事业的开始并不意味着它一定会有一个完美的结局，中国不是没有开始过封建化，但是现在怎么样呢？第三是无论是富拉尼统治者当年借助伊斯兰教进行圣战的行为，还是今天富拉尼人在西非广泛分布，对分布地其他民族具有的经济优势地位并使得与之混居的其他民族富拉尼化的现实情况来看，封建化过程显然是在某种程度上发生了。至于其他证据还需要他人补充，毕竟想要在中国了解西非社会的历史和现实，确实是十分困难的。